



ote-taking has always been a chore—more so during those unstructured, so-called brainstorming or ideation meetings, during which people jump from idea to idea; or worse, go round in circles but still expect lucid minutes of the meeting within one business day. Whether it's capturing your professor's insightful lecture, or documenting details of that research project—good notes that can be referred to and understood weeks or months after they are written, are an important asset.

The tools we are going to discuss mimic typical note-taking styles that you are already aware of. You may have written datelined journals, or notes in folders. You may have discovered the convenience of a wiki format for taking notes. What these tools (also called 'outliners') bring you are additional facilities that paper and pencil just cannot match.



**Note:** The References section of this article contains links to each tool's website.

### RedNoteBook

There aren't very many pure journal applications in Linux; at least, I could not find any that stand out. RedNoteBook is feature-rich, and simple to use, even if it has a slightly odd way of assigning categories and tags to journal entries.

From the screenshot in Figure 1, you will

note the three vertical panes. The left top is the calendar, and the left bottom is a search pane with a weighted keyword cloud, and a search-as-you-type text entry pane. Actually, the right-most pane is a distraction, except when you create a new journal entry.

To create an entry, just click on a date and start typing. Make sure you are in edit mode—the *Edit/Preview* button toggles this. Wiki syntax is supported: 'underline', '**bold**', and '**Title**' work as expected. A *Ctrl+D* gets you the date stamp. A neat feature is templates based on weekdays. For instance, the journal template for Friday is 5.txt. With weekday templates, you can automatically log those pre-scheduled activities like the staff meeting on Mondays, and the design review meeting on Thursdays.

Once you have created an entry, at the right-most pane, use the 'New Entry' button to assign a category and a sub-category to your journal entry. You can also add optional tags. It is possible to export journal entries to HTML, filtered by categories and a date range.

Multiple entries (say, for different projects), under different exclusive categories for a particular date, are not possible within the same journal. Of course, you can always create multiple journals as a trivial solution.

### NoteCase

Just do an 'Insert Node', or hit the *<Insert>* key to get started. The first node is the root